

Cascadia Institute of Design
School of Interaction Design

INSD 490: Game Studies Seminar
Reading Packet and Course Schedule -- Fall 2026

Instructor:	Professor Adrian Walsh	Location:	Studio D, Main Building
Class Time:	Wednesdays 3:00 to 5:30 PM	Office:	Harmon Hall 214
Office Hours:	Tuesdays 1:00 to 3:00 PM	Email:	a.walsh@cid.edu

Course Description

This seminar examines video games as cultural and aesthetic objects, focusing on narrative structure, player agency, representation, and the ethics of interactive storytelling. Students engage with primary scholarship in game studies and apply critical frameworks to independent game projects. The course concludes with a research paper connecting theory to one student-developed or commercially released game.

Required Texts

- Juul, Jesper. Half-Real: Video Games between Real Rules and Fictional Worlds. MIT Press, 2005.
- Flanagan, Mary. Critical Play: Radical Game Design. MIT Press, 2009.
- Anthropy, Anna. Rise of the Videogame Zinesters. Seven Stories Press, 2012.
- Shaw, Adrienne. Gaming at the Edge: Sexuality and Gender at the Margins of Gamer Culture. University of Minnesota Press, 2014.
- PDF supplementary readings distributed via the course portal.

Weekly Schedule

Date	Topic	Readings Due
Oct 7, 2026	What is a game? Foundations and definitions	Juul ch. 1 to 2; Flanagan, intro
Oct 14, 2026	Rules, fiction, and meaning	Juul ch. 3 to 5
Oct 21, 2026	Critical play and countergame design	Flanagan ch. 1 and 4; Anthropy ch. 1 to 3
Oct 28, 2026	Zinesters, independents, and access	Anthropy ch. 4 to 6; Shaw, intro
Nov 4, 2026	Representation and the margins of gamer culture	Shaw ch. 1 to 3
Nov 11, 2026	Narrative systems and dialogue design	PDF packet A (portal); paper topic due
Nov 18, 2026	Player agency, authorship, and procedural rhetoric	PDF packet B (portal)
Dec 2, 2026	Memory, adaptation, and family narrative in games	PDF packet C; Shaw ch. 6

Dec 9, 2026	Paper presentations and workshop	Final paper due by 5:30 PM
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Assignments and Grading

Weekly reading responses (8 responses, 5% each)	40%
Paper topic and outline, due November 11, 2026	10%
Final research paper, 3,500 to 4,500 words, due December 9, 2026	40%
Participation and in-class discussion	10%

Policies

Late work will lose one letter grade per calendar day. Extension requests must be submitted at least 48 hours before the due date. All written work must be your own. The use of undisclosed AI writing tools is not permitted. Academic integrity violations will be reported to the CID Academic Standards Committee per standard institute policy.